PRINTABLE EDITION

The Yooper Dictionary

How we talk up here in Michigan's Upper Peninsula, eh

153 words and sayings, each with a plain meaning and an example

Stick it on the fridge at camp, hand it to the trolls visiting from below the bridge, or settle that argument about pasties once and for all.

2 Broke Yoopers

How to use this dictionary

Words are in A to Z order. Each one gives the word, how to say it when that helps, a plain meaning and a short example. "Also" lists other spellings you might see.

Every word was checked against a real web page that ties it to the U.P. The page we used is named in small print under each word.

Want the free, searchable version for your phone? Visit 2brokeyoopers.github.io/tools/yooper-dictionary and look up any word in a second, even if you spell it like a troll.

Know a word we missed? Thank you for helping! Please send it to 2brokeyoopers@gmail.com.

# #

906 (nine-oh-six) *n.*
The telephone area code for the whole U.P., used as a proud nickname for it.
"*Born and raised in the 906, and proud of it.*"
Also: da 906, the 906
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

A

Ahmeek *n.*
A Keweenaw village named from the Ojibwe word amik, meaning beaver.
"*We stopped at Ahmeek to look for beavers.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Ahmeek, Michigan

B

bal maiden *n.*
A woman who worked at a Cornish mine.
"*A bal maiden's shout echoed down the shaft.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Miners knew to feed oggies to knockers

bear roll *n.*
A dance at Hancock's winter festival that everyone is invited to join.
"*Everybody joined the bear roll to warm up in the cold.*"
Checked at: TV6 (WLUC): Heikinpäivä highlights Finnish-American culture

beater *n.*
An old car or truck that still runs, more or less.
"*My beater has more rust than paint, but it starts every time.*"
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

Big Gus *n.*
The giant chainsaw at Da Yoopers Tourist Trap near Ishpeming, said to be the world's biggest.
"*We took a picture next to Big Gus.*"
Checked at: Da Yoopers (Wikipedia)

Big Mac *n.*
A nickname for the Mackinac Bridge.
"*The Big Mac looked like a sparkly necklace at night.*"
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

Boozhoo *interj.*
The Ojibwe word for hello.
"*Boozhoo! Welcome to the powwow!*"
Checked at: Mining Journal: French voyageurs in the U.P.

buck pole *n.*
A pole where hunters hang their deer so everyone in town can see them on opening day.
"*Our whole town came to look at the buck pole.*"
Checked at: Newberry News

bug juice *n.*
Bug spray. Yoopers joke it is the best-selling cologne in the U.P.
"*Pass the bug juice before we hike to the falls.*"
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

C

cabin fever *n.*
That restless, stuck-inside feeling at the end of a long U.P. winter, just before spring fever.
"*By March, cabin fever had us building a snowman in the living room.*"
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

Calumet (KAL-yuh-MET) *n.*
A Keweenaw village in the old Copper Country. Locals say it a little differently than outsiders.
"*Calumet gets lots of snow and has an old opera house.*"
Checked at: Calumet, Michigan (Wikipedia)

camp *n.*
A Yooper's second home, often a cabin in the woods that may or may not have power or running water.
"*No phone signal at camp, so we played cards all weekend.*"
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

Cheeseheads *n.*
A joking Yooper name for neighbors in Wisconsin, the "banana belt" to the south.
"*The Cheeseheads came across the border for our fish fry.*"
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

chook (chook, like book) *n.*
A knit winter hat. The word comes from the French-Canadian word toque.
"*Pull your chook down over your ears before you go sledding.*"
Also: chuke, chooks
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

choppers *n.*
Deerskin mittens with a wool mitten inside. Warmer than gloves.
"*Lost one of my choppers in the snowbank, so now I have one warm hand.*"
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

Copper Country *n.*
The part of the western U.P. around the Keweenaw where lots of copper was mined.
"*My great-grandpa worked in Copper Country mines.*"
Checked at: Copper Country (Wikipedia)

Cousin Jack *n.*
A nickname for Cornish miners who came to work in the Copper Country.
"*Great-grandpa was a Cousin Jack who dug copper near Calumet.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech: An Interior Ellis Island (Cornish)

Cousin Jennies *n.*
The wives of Cornish miners, who brought saffron buns and the pasty to the U.P.
"*The Cousin Jennies baked saffron buns for Sunday.*"
Checked at: Star Lake: The Pasty of Michigan Miners

crib *n.*
A Cornish word for a miner's lunch break, brought to the Copper Country by Cornish miners.
"*The miners stopped for crib and opened their lunch pails.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Miners knew to feed oggies to knockers

crick *n.*
Yooper way of saying creek, a small stream.
"*Turn left right after da crick.*"
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

croust *n.*
Another Cornish word for a miner's lunch break, part of Copper Country mining talk.
"*At croust, the team sat down to eat their pasties.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Miners knew to feed oggies to knockers

cudighi (KOOD-ih-gee) *n.*
A spicy Italian sausage that is a U.P. classic, often linked to Ishpeming.
"*A cudighi sandwich with onions makes a cold day better.*"
Also: cudighis
Checked at: Movoto: 10 Things Only People From The Upper Peninsula Understand

D

da *art.*
Yooper way of saying "the."
"*Meet me by da lake at sunset.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Da Yoopers

da bridge *n.*
The Mackinac Bridge, which joins the U.P. to the rest of Michigan.
"*We crossed da bridge and everybody in the car cheered.*"
Also: the bridge
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

da Mitten *n.*
Yooper nickname for the Lower Peninsula, which is shaped like a mitten on a map.
“*Our cousins live down in da Mitten, near the thumb.*”
Also: the mitten
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

da U.P. (you pee) *n.*
The Upper Peninsula of Michigan. Say the two letters, U and P.
“*We're heading up to da U.P. for blueberry season.*”
Also: the U.P., U.P.
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

Da Yoopers *n.*
A comedy band from Ishpeming famous for funny songs about U.P. life.
“*Dad sings Da Yoopers songs on every road trip.*”
Checked at: Northern Express: You Said It! Your Guide to Michigan Slang

deer camp *n.*
The hunting cabin in the woods for November deer season, and also the two weeks of that season itself.
“*Uncle Ray has been talking about deer camp since the Fourth of July.*”
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

deer car *n.*
An older, beat-up car you drive when deer might jump out.
“*We took da deer car on da back road.*”
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

dis and dat *phr.*
Yoopers often say a D sound for TH, so "this and that" becomes "dis and dat."
“*Dis is da best fish fry in da whole county, eh.*”
Also: dis, dat, den, dem, dose
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

downstate *adj.*
In the lower part of Michigan, away from the U.P.
“*Our downstate cousins visit every summer for the fishing.*”
Checked at: Wikipedia: State of Superior

E

eh *interj.*
Added to the end of a sentence to mean "right?" or "don't you think?"
“*Nice day for a drive along the lake, eh?*”
Also: eh?
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

Escanaba (ES-kuh-NAH-buh) *n.*
A port city in the U.P. on Lake Michigan, in Delta County.
“*Grandpa grew up in Escanaba, right on Lake Michigan.*”
Checked at: Escanaba, Michigan (Wikipedia)

Escanaba in da Moonlight *n.*
A funny movie about a family deer camp, filmed near Escanaba, that uses U.P. talk.
“*We watched Escanaba in da Moonlight before deer season.*”
Checked at: Escanaba in da Moonlight (Wikipedia)

Esky *n.*
Short, friendly nickname for the city of Escanaba in the U.P.
“*Let's meet in Esky for lunch.*”
Checked at: Escanaba, Michigan (Wikipedia)

F

flatlander *n.*
A nickname for someone from the Lower Peninsula.
“*The flatlander had never seen snow that deep in October.*”
Also: flatlanders
Checked at: Awesome Mitten: Michigan Words, Slang, and Pronunciations

fudgie *n.*
A tourist up north, named for all the fudge visitors buy before they go home.
“*The fudgies cleaned out the fudge shop by noon, eh.*”
Also: fudgies, fudgey
Checked at: Michigan Public: The vocabulary of yoopers, trolls and fudgies

G

Gitche Gumee (GITCH-ee GOO-mee) *n.*
Longfellow's spelling of the Ojibwe name for Lake Superior, meaning great sea.
"*The old song calls Lake Superior Gitche Gumee.*"
Also: Gichigami, Gichi-gami, Gitchi Gami
Checked at: Lake Superior (Wikipedia)

God's Country *n.*
A loving name Yoopers use for the U.P. and its beauty.
"*Fall colors along the lake? Yep, that's God's Country.*"
Checked at: Sault Ste. Marie CVB: What does it mean to be a Yooper?

go store *phr.*
Yoopers often drop "to the," a habit from Finnish, which has no words for "a" or "the."
"*Hold on, I gotta go store for milk and bread.*"
Also: let's go store, go Shopko
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

Grand Marais (grand muh-RAY) *n.*
A tiny U.P. town on Lake Superior near the Grand Sable Dunes, with a harbor.
"*We watched the waves roll into Grand Marais.*"
Checked at: Grand Marais, Michigan (Wikipedia)

Graveyard of the Great Lakes *n.*
A nickname for the stretch of Lake Superior near Whitefish Point where many ships sank.
"*The museum at Whitefish Point tells about the Graveyard of the Great Lakes.*"
Checked at: Whitefish Point Light (Wikipedia)

H

have a good one *phr.*
The usual friendly goodbye up north.
"*Thanks for the help with the boat, have a good one!*"
Checked at: Northern Express: You Said It! Your Guide to Michigan Slang

Heikinpäivä (HAY-kin-PIE-vah) *n.*
A midwinter festival in Hancock celebrating Finnish culture, with parades, games and the wife-carrying contest.
"*We bundled up for the Heikinpäivä parade in Hancock.*"
Checked at: Michigan Public: Hancock celebrates Heikinpäivä

Heikki Lunta (HAY-kee LOON-tah) *n.*
The snow god of U.P. folklore, born from Finnish-American Keweenaw culture. Some folks dance to ask him for snow.
"*The snowmobile club did a little dance for Heikki Lunta.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Heikki Lunta

hetta *adj.*
Restless, wound up, full of energy. From Finnish.
"*The kids were so hetta on the first snow day they bounced off the walls.*"
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

holy wah *interj.*
The Yooper way to say "wow!" when something is surprising or amazing.
"*Holy wah, that snowbank is taller than the mailbox!*"
Also: holy wah!, holyowha
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

Houghton (HOH-tun) *n.*
A Copper Country city on the Keweenaw. The gh is silent, so it sounds like HOH-tun.
"*We drove to Houghton to watch the snow sculptures.*"
Checked at: Houghton, Michigan (Wikipedia)

I

ihana (EE-hah-nah) *adj.*
Finnish for lovely or wonderful.
"*That sunset over Lake Superior was just ihana.*"
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

inning *n.*
One round in the sauna, then a cool-off outside.
"*I'll do one more inning, then jump in da lake.*"
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

Ishpeming (ISH-puh-ming) *n.*
A U.P. iron-mining city in Marquette County, home of Da Yoopers.
"*Ishpeming has a ski jump and a great tourist trap.*"
Checked at: Ishpeming, Michigan (Wikipedia)

J

Jampot *n.*
A bakery in Eagle Harbor, run by monks, that sells thimbleberry jam in the Keweenaw.
"*We bought a jar of jam at the Jampot.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette

Juhannus *n.*
The Finnish Midsummer holiday on the longest day of the year, celebrated with fire, sauna and community.
"*We watched the Juhannus bonfire glow late into the long evening.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Hancock's Juhannus truly Finnish

Juhannus salko *n.*
The Midsummer pole, dressed with birch boughs and greens, raised each year on Quincy Green in Hancock.
"*We hung birch boughs on the Juhannus salko.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Copper Country Finns celebrate Juhannus

K

kala mojakka *n.*
A Finnish fish stew made in the U.P.
"*Nothing warms you up after ice fishing like a bowl of kala mojakka.*"
Also: kala mojaka, mojakka
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

Keweenaw (KEE-wuh-naw) *n.*
The northern peninsula that sticks out into Lake Superior, famous for copper and snow.
"*The Keweenaw gets so much snow that kids ski to school.*"
Checked at: Keweenaw Peninsula (Wikipedia)

kibble *n.*
A bucket used to haul rock up out of a Copper Country mine.
"*The kibble rose slowly up the shaft.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech: An Interior Ellis Island (Cornish)

kicksled *n.*
A Finnish sled you push along standing on one runner, raced by kids at Keweenaw winter festivals.
"*We raced our kicksleds across the snowy Quincy Green.*"
Checked at: Keweenaw Now (Heikinpäivä listings)

kiitos (KEE-tohs) *interj.*
Finnish for "thank you," still heard in Keweenaw families.
"*Kiitos for the coffee and the cardamom bread!*"
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

kippo *n.*
The wooden ladle used to pour water on hot sauna rocks.
"*Hand me da kippo and I'll make some steam.*"
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

Kitch-iti-kipi *n.*
A big clear spring near Manistique whose Ojibwe name means big cold spring.
"*We rode the raft over Kitch-iti-kipi and saw the bubbling sand.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Kitch-iti-kipi

kokko *n.*
A big Midsummer bonfire; one has been lit at Toivola's Agate Beach since the 1890s.
"*The kokko at Agate Beach lit up the whole shoreline.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Copper Country Finns celebrate Juhannus

korppu *n.*
A twice-baked, crunchy Finnish bread, like the cinnamon toast made in Trenary, for dunking in coffee.
"*Dunk your korppu in hot cocoa and it gets soft.*"
Checked at: 103.3 WKFR: Why Are Michigan's Yoopers SO Obsessed With Stale Toast?

Kuparisaari *n.*
Finnish name meaning copper island, used for the northern half of the Keweenaw Peninsula.
"*Grandpa told stories about Kuparisaari, where his family first settled.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech: An Interior Ellis Island (Finns)

L

lake-effect snow *n.*
Heavy snow made when cold wind picks up moisture from a warm lake, like Lake Superior.
"*Lake-effect snow buried the Keweenaw again last night.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech News

L'Anse (LAHNSS) *n.*
A village in Baraga County on Keweenaw Bay. The s at the end is said, as in lance.
"*We went ice fishing near L'Anse.*"
Checked at: L'Anse, Michigan (Wikipedia)

lats *n.*
Skis, often homemade ones. From Finnish.
"*Grandma still has the old wooden lats hanging in the garage.*"
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

Les Cheneaux *n.*
A chain of islands in the eastern U.P. whose French name means the channels.
"*We kayaked around Les Cheneaux all afternoon.*"
Checked at: Mining Journal: French voyageurs in the U.P.

lopers *n.*
Another U.P. nickname for people from the Lower Peninsula.
"*The lopers waved at us from the rest stop.*"
Checked at: Movoto: 10 Things Only People From The Upper Peninsula Understand

löyly *n.*
The hot steam you make by tossing water on the sauna rocks.
"*Hang onto your hat when somebody throws more löyly on the rocks!*"
Checked at: Promote Michigan: Saunas in the Snow

M

Mackinac (MAK-uh-naw) *n.*
The island and straits between the two peninsulas. It is spelled with c but said like Mackinaw.
"*Say Mackinac like MAK-uh-naw and everyone will smile.*"
Checked at: Straits of Mackinac (Wikipedia)

make wood *phr.*
To cut and split logs for firewood.
"*We have to make wood all Saturday so the stove stays happy all winter.*"
Also: making wood
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

makkara (MUCK-ah-dah) *n.*
Finnish word for sausage, used by Finnish families in the U.P.
"*We roasted makkara over the fire at camp.*"
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

Manistique (man-iss-TEEK) *n.*
A small U.P. city on Lake Michigan in Schoolcraft County.
"*We stopped in Manistique to walk the lakeshore.*"
Checked at: Manistique, Michigan (Wikipedia)

manoomin *n.*
The Ojibwe word for wild rice, a grain that grows on water.
"*We learned how manoomin is harvested at the wild rice camp.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Manoomin traditions

manoominator *n.*
A machine that speeds up winnowing wild rice at the Keweenaw Bay rice camp.
"*The manoominator finished the winnowing much faster.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Manoomin traditions

Marquette (mar-KET) *n.*
The biggest city in the U.P., on Lake Superior. The last syllable is KET, not KAY.
"*Marquette is where we go for the big hospital and the big park.*"
Checked at: Marquette, Michigan (Wikipedia)

Marquette Iron Range *n.*
The famous iron ore deposit around Ishpeming and Negaunee in the U.P.
"*Iron from the Marquette Iron Range went to build ships.*"
Checked at: Marquette Iron Range (Wikipedia)

Menominee (muh-NOM-uh-nee) *n.*
A city in the southern U.P. on the Wisconsin border.
"*Menominee sits right across the river from Wisconsin.*"
Checked at: Menominee, Michigan (Wikipedia)

Mighty Mac *n.*
Another nickname for the Mackinac Bridge.
"*The wind was blowing hard, but the Mighty Mac stood strong.*"
Checked at: Northern Express: You Said It! Your Guide to Michigan Slang

Miigwech *interj.*
The Ojibwe word for thank you.
"*Miigwech for sharing your story!*"
Checked at: Mining Journal: French voyageurs in the U.P.

Munising (MEW-nuh-sing) *n.*
A U.P. town on Lake Superior, where boats leave for the Pictured Rocks.
"*We rode a boat from Munising to see the cliffs.*"
Checked at: Munising, Michigan (Wikipedia)

N

Negaunee *n.*
A U.P. town whose name comes from an Ojibwe word for leading or being in front.
"*We cheered at the Negaunee game.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Negaunee, Michigan

nisu *n.*
A sweet Finnish bread flavored with cardamom, often eaten with coffee.
"*Grandma baked nisu, and we ate it warm after sauna.*"
Checked at: Promote Michigan: Saunas in the Snow

noseeums *n.*
Tiny biting gnats so small you can hardly see them.
"*The noseeums found us the minute we sat down by the campfire.*"
Also: no-see-ums
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

O

oggy *n.*
A Cornish word for a pasty, shouted down mine shafts at lunchtime.
"*Mom packed an oggy for my lunch.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Miners knew to feed oggies to knockers

Old Reliable *n.*
Nickname of the Quincy Mine in the Copper Country, which paid its investors every year for a long time.
"*The tour guide called the Quincy Mine Old Reliable.*"
Checked at: Quincy Mine (Wikipedia)

Ontonagon (ON-tuh-NAH-gun) *n.*
A village in the western U.P. on Lake Superior.
"*Ontonagon is a quiet town by the big lake.*"
Checked at: Ontonagon, Michigan (Wikipedia)

ope *interj.*
A quick little "oops" or "excuse me" when you bump into something.
"*Ope, let me just squeeze past ya to get the ketchup.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

opening day *n.*
The first day of rifle deer season, a big day up north. Some schools even close.
"*The whole town was quiet on opening day because everyone was in the woods.*"
Also: opener
Checked at: Awesome Mitten: Michigan Words, Slang, and Pronunciations

P

pank *v.*
To pat or pack something down, like snow, so it is firm.
"*Pank the snow down good or your fort will fall over.*"
Also: pank it, panked
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

pannukakku *n.*
A Finnish oven pancake, puffy and custardy.
"*Pannukakku with raspberry jam is the best Sunday breakfast.*"
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

pasty (PASS-tee) *n.*
A folded pie crust stuffed with meat, potato, rutabaga and onion. A U.P. favorite brought by Cornish miners. Say PASS-tee.
"*One warm pasty in your coat pocket and you are set till supper.*"
Also: pasties, pastie
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

Pictured Rocks *n.*
Tall colorful sandstone cliffs on Lake Superior near Munising, a national lakeshore.
"*We took a boat tour to see the Pictured Rocks.*"
Checked at: Pictured Rocks National Lakeshore (Wikipedia)

Plaidurday *n.*
A U.P. holiday for wearing plaid, held the first Friday of October.
"*Wear your best flannel shirt tomorrow, it's Plaidurday!*"
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

Porkies *n.*
Friendly nickname for the Porcupine Mountains in the western U.P., a big wild park near Lake Superior.
"*We hiked the Porkies to see Lake of the Clouds.*"
Checked at: Porcupine Mountains (Wikipedia)

portage *v.*
To carry a canoe over land between waterways, as the voyageurs did in the Keweenaw.
"*We had to portage the canoe around the rapids.*"
Checked at: Mining Journal: French voyageurs in the U.P.

pre'neer *adv.*
"Pretty near," meaning almost or very close.
"*We're pre'neer to camp, just one more two-track.*"
Also: pretty near, preneer
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

Presque Isle *n.*
A French place name meaning almost an island, found on the U.P. map.
"*We hiked out to Presque Isle to see the waves.*"
Checked at: Mining Journal: French voyageurs in the U.P.

puuroa (BOO-doh-ah) *n.*
Finnish word Keweenaw families use for hot oatmeal porridge.
"*A bowl of puuroa with brown sugar keeps you warm all morning.*"
Also: puuro
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

R

rezzu *adj.*
Messy or scruffy looking. From the Finnish for "rag boy."
"*Change those rezzu jeans before we go see Grandma.*"
Checked at: Eighteen Uncles: Upper Peninsula Finnish-isms

Rootbeer Falls *n.*
Another name for Tahquamenon Falls, because the water looks golden-brown like root beer.
"*We stood at Rootbeer Falls and took a family photo.*"
Checked at: Tahquamenon Falls State Park (Wikipedia)

S

saffron cake *n.*
A golden Cornish cake or bread flavored with saffron, served at Cornish picnics.
"*Aunt Jean brought saffron cake to the picnic.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech: An Interior Ellis Island (Cornish)

sauna (SOW-nuh) *n.*
A small hot steam room from Finland. In the U.P. you say SOW-nuh, not SAW-nuh.
"*After sauna we rolled in the snow and laughed like crazy.*"
Checked at: Movoto: 10 Things Only People From The Upper Peninsula Understand

Say ya to da U.P., eh! *phr.*
A famous Yooper motto on mugs, shirts and bumper stickers.
"*Our truck has a bumper sticker that says Say ya to da U.P., eh!*"
Also: Say yah to dah U.P. eh
Checked at: Michigan Public: Dat's what da Yoopers say

shut the lights *phr.*
A way of saying turn off the lights.
"*Shut the lights when you leave camp, hey.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

side by each *phr.*
Yooper way of saying "side by side."
"*We sat side by each on the dock and watched the sunset.*"
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

sisu (SEE-soo) *n.*
A Finnish word for grit and never giving up. Yoopers say you need it to get through winter.
"*Shoveling the driveway three times in one day takes real sisu.*"
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

skeetoes *n.*
Mosquitoes. A joke calls them the U.P.'s native bird because they come out by the thousands.
"*The skeetoes are so big this year they need their own fishing license.*"
Also: skeeters, skeetoes
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

sled *n.*
A snowmobile.
"*I hafta fix my sled before da first snow.*"
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

sledneck *n.*
Someone who loves riding snowmobiles.
"*Da sledneck zoomed past our cabin, waving.*"
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

smelt dipping *n.*
A spring sport where people scoop small silvery fish from streams at night with long-handled nets.
"*Smelt dipping with flashlights was my favorite spring night.*"
Checked at: Smelt dipping (Wikipedia)

snowbelt *n.*
A place downwind of a big lake that gets huge piles of lake-effect snow, like parts of the U.P.
"*The Keweenaw is the snowiest snowbelt around.*"
Checked at: Lake-effect snow (Wikipedia)

Sorels *n.*
A brand of warm winter boots so common in the U.P. that the name stands for good winter boots.
"*Lace up your Sorels, we're going to watch the snowplow go by.*"
Checked at: Movoto: 10 Things Only People From The Upper Peninsula Understand

stamp mill *n.*
A big building where heavy hammers crushed rock to pull the copper out.
"*The stamp mill by the lake is now a quiet landmark.*"
Checked at: Stamp sand (Wikipedia)

stamp sand *n.*
Black or gray sand left over after crushing copper ore in old mills.
"*The beach near the old mill is covered with stamp sand.*"
Checked at: Stamp sand (Wikipedia)

St. George's Day *n.*
April 23, a Cornish holiday with parades and concerts in Copper Country towns.
"*We went to the St. George's Day concert in Calumet.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech: An Interior Ellis Island (Cornish)

St. Ignace (IG-nuss) *n.*
A city at the north end of the Mackinac Bridge, where you first land in the U.P.
"*We got fudge in St. Ignace right after the bridge.*"
Checked at: St. Ignace, Michigan (Wikipedia)

stope *n.*
A mining method for removing ore, and a Cornish word still used in mines.
"*The crew worked in the stope all day.*"
Checked at: Michigan Tech: An Interior Ellis Island (Cornish)

Stormy Kromer *n.*
A wool cap with fold-down ear flaps, the most popular winter hat in the U.P.
"*Grandpa won't leave the house without his red Stormy Kromer.*"
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

stump jumper *n.*
An off-road buggy for the bush, or a Yooper who works in the woods.
"*The stump jumper bounced down the trail to the berry patch.*"
Checked at: God's Country: Da Yoopers Glossary

St. Urho's Day *n.*
March 16, a playful Finnish-American holiday honoring a saint who chased grasshoppers away to save the grapes.
"*We wore purple on St. Urho's Day to cheer for the grapes.*"
Checked at: Grand Master of Masons in Michigan - Yooper Style

swampers *n.*
Boots with rubber bottoms and leather tops for mud and slush, so you wear them most of the year.
"*Spring in the U.P. means swampers by the door and mud on the porch.*"
Checked at: Movoto: 10 Things Only People From The Upper Peninsula Understand

T

Tahquamenon (tuh-KWAH-muh-non) *n.*
The name of a U.P. river and falls; nobody is sure what the word first meant.
"*The Tahquamenon Falls looked like root beer rushing over the edge.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Tahquamenon River

the Soo (Soo) *n.*
Short name for Sault Ste. Marie, home of the Soo Locks. Sault is said "Soo."
"*Let's drive to the Soo and watch a giant freighter go through the locks.*"
Also: Soo, Sault, Sault Ste. Marie
Checked at: Awesome Mitten: Michigan Words, Slang, and Pronunciations

the Yoop *n.*
A short, friendly nickname for the U.P.
"*Nothing beats a summer night in the Yoop.*"
Also: da Yoop
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

thimbleberry *n.*
A soft wild berry made into jam in the Keweenaw.
"*Grandma made thimbleberry jam for our toast.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: Thimbleberry

Toivo and Eino *n.*
Two Finnish names for the lovable, mixed-up characters in a whole family of Yooper jokes.
"*Did you hear the one where Toivo and Eino try to ice fish in July?*"
Also: Eino and Toivo, Toivo, Eino
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

Trenary Toast *n.*
Crunchy cinnamon toast from the town of Trenary, a Finnish twice-baked bread made for dunking in coffee.
"*Dunk your Trenary Toast in coffee and listen to the crunch.*"
Also: Trenary
Checked at: Wikipedia: Trenary, Michigan

troll *n.*
A friendly nickname for someone from Michigan's Lower Peninsula, because they live "under the bridge."
"*Our troll cousins drove up for the weekend and loved every minute.*"
Checked at: Michigan Public: The vocabulary of yoopers, trolls and fudgies

tull *n.*
An old-style hard mining hat made of thick felt and resin.
"*His tull kept his head safe underground.*"
Checked at: Mining Gazette: Miners knew to feed oggies to knockers

two-track *n.*
A narrow dirt road with two wheel ruts, found all over the woods.
"*We bumped down a two-track to find the lake.*"
Checked at: Michigan Blue Magazine

U

uff da *interj.*
A Scandinavian way to say "oh my!" for surprise, tiredness or relief.
"*Uff da, that was a lot of snow to shovel.*"
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

UP200 *n.*
A famous sled dog race from Marquette to Grand Marais and back, held each winter.
"*We cheered for the sled dogs at the UP200 in Marquette.*"
Also: U.P. 200
Checked at: Marbles Kids Museum / NMU History

Upper Hand *n.*
A nickname for the U.P. Hold your left hand over your right and the top hand is the U.P.
"*Point to the Upper Hand and show us where camp is.*"
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

V

vihta *n.*
A bundle of birch twigs used to gently brush the skin in a sauna; also called vasta.
"*Uncle Toivo soaked the vihta in water before our sauna.*"
Checked at: Promote Michigan: Saunas in the Snow

voyageur *n.*
A French-Canadian boatman who carried goods and people between fur trading posts.
"*The voyageur paddled his canoe across Lake Superior.*"
Checked at: Mining Journal: French voyageurs in the U.P.

W

wife-carrying contest *n.*
A silly race at Hancock's winter festival where one person carries another through an obstacle course.
“*Mom and Dad trained all week for the wife-carrying contest.*”
Checked at: TV6 (WLUC): Heikinpäivä highlights Finnish-American culture

Y

ya *interj.*
"Yes." From the German and Scandinavian word ja.
“*Ya, we'll be there by supper.*”
Also: yah, ja
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

yah, eh? *phr.*
Yooper for "I know, right?"
“*Best pasty you ever had? Yah, eh?*”
Also: ya eh
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

yah hey *interj.*
"No way! You're kidding me!"
“*You caught a walleye that big? Yah hey!*”
Also: yah sure hey, ya hey
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

yeah, no *phr.*
A polite Michigan way to answer. The last word is the real answer, so "yeah, no" means no and "no, yeah" means yes.
“*Swim in Lake Superior in April? Yeah, no.*”
Also: ya no, yeah no, no yeah, no, yeah
Checked at: Islands: 5 Local Michigan Slang Phrases

yet *adv.*
Used to mean "still," as in "I need to clean this room yet."
“*I gotta shovel da walk yet before supper.*”
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

Yoopanese *n.*
A joking name for the way Yoopers talk, also called Yooper English.
“*After one week at camp my cousin was fluent in Yoopanese.*”
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

Yooper (YOO-per) *n.*
A person from Michigan's Upper Peninsula. The name comes from the letters U.P.
“*Grandpa says you can take a Yooper out of the woods, but he will find his way back.*”
Checked at: Life in the 906: Yooper Terms

Yooper Cologne *n.*
Bug spray used to fight U.P. mosquitoes.
“*Better dab on some Yooper Cologne before the campfire.*”
Checked at: How to Speak Like a Yooper (Soles of My Traveling Shoes)

Yooperland *n.*
A fun name for the U.P. itself.
“*Welcome to Yooperland, where the snow is deep and the people are friendly.*”
Checked at: Mental Floss: 10 Regional Words From Waaaay Northern Michigan

Yooperlite (YOO-per-lite) *n.*
A gray rock from the U.P. shoreline that glows orange under a UV flashlight.
“*We found a Yooperlite on the beach after dark.*”
Checked at: KTTC News

Yooper Scooper *n.*
A giant snow shovel made for deep U.P. snow.
“*Dad grabbed the Yooper Scooper and cleared da whole driveway.*”
Checked at: 29 Things People From The Upper Peninsula Have To Explain (Movoto)

Yooper talk *n.*
The way people speak in the U.P., with its own sounds, words and sayings.
“*Spend a summer in Marquette and you'll pick up Yooper talk fast.*”
Checked at: Michigan Public: Dat's what da Yoopers say

you betcha *phr.*
"Yes, for sure!" A happy, no-doubt-about-it yes.
“*Want a second piece of thimbleberry pie? You betcha!*”
Also: youbetcha
Checked at: A Walk in the WoRds: More on the Yooper Dialect

youse *pron.*
"You" when talking to more than one person, like "you guys."
“*Are youse coming to the fish fry Friday?*”
Also: youse guys, you'se guys
Checked at: Wikipedia: North-Central American English

Thanks for reading, and have a good one!

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